

Prion-Style Defensive Telemetry System (CENTEL Concept)

Executive Summary

We present a conceptual “prion defense” system: a **polymorphic, passive, inert telemetry artifact** (e.g. cookies, sessions, telemetry packets) that replicates within **U.S.-controlled networks**, collects *only voluntarily exposed attacker metadata*, and “pings” home to American infrastructure. Crucially, it **never executes code or exfiltrates data from foreign systems**—it only gathers what an adversary willingly reveals by interacting with decoys. By design, it remains fully defensive (legal under the CFAA) ¹, while forcing attackers to expose their environment (IPs, OS, tools) and exposing their TTPs. We analyze legal guardrails (CFAA, espionage norms) and threat models (nation-state APTs vs criminal opportunists) ² ³. We then outline a rigorous technical blueprint: artifact formats, polymorphism strategies, replication (“mitosis”) logic, environment-fingerprinting, stealthy ping-back protocols, SIEM integration, and telemetry schema. Detection/avoidance trade-offs and operational playbooks (deployment, monitoring, escalation) are detailed, along with failure modes/mitigations and an ethics/compliance checklist. Finally, we propose a phased implementation roadmap, including prototyping and testing metrics. Tables compare design options, and mermaid diagrams illustrate the system lifecycle and data flows. This CENTEL-grade design ensures America’s critical systems can covertly “turn the tables” on intruders, gathering maximum intelligence while adhering to the boundary of pure defense ¹ ⁴.

Legal & Ethical Guardrails (CFAA, Espionage, Guidance)

- **CFAA (18 U.S.C. §1030):** Prohibits “access without authorization or exceeding authorized access” ¹. Our artifacts **do not access or execute on attacker systems**; they only operate within our own network, collecting data from voluntary interactions. This aligns with legal consensus: honeytokens and beacons are lawful if no unauthorized intrusion occurs ¹ ⁵. The CARD Act (CFAA) has no self-defense carve-out, so as one analysis notes, the “line” of legality is the boundary of one’s own network ⁴. By never “hacking back”, we stay on the defensible side of that line ¹ ⁴.
- **Espionage & Sovereignty:** International norms (Tallinn Manual, DoD Law) emphasize no unauthorized cross-border intrusion ⁶ ¹. Our design only “reports” what an attacker exposes by handling the artifact, without extracting foreign data or breaching foreign networks. We monitor only our own asset’s status. This principle of *purpose limitation* and *sovereignty* means we act only on data generated in our domain ¹ ⁷.
- **Case Law & Guidance:** Passive deception tools (honeypots, honeytokens, monitoring) are widely endorsed as long as they stay internal ¹ ⁵. Legal commentary stresses *no offensive intrusion* – no RCE, no port scanning others, no external payloads ⁶ ⁸. Fail-safes like **environmental fingerprinting** (activate only outside home network), time delays, and manual control are recommended ⁹ ¹⁰. Ethical frameworks similarly urge proportionality and minimization: only gather what’s necessary for defense ⁷.

In summary, our system respects legal guardrails by remaining **100% defensive** and **American-telemetry-bounded**. We never exfiltrate or execute on the adversary’s machine ¹. All data comes from interactions the attacker initiates with our artifacts, akin to “observing voluntary actions on our property.” This is well within lawful active defense practices ¹ ⁵.

Threat Models

- **Nation-State / Advanced Threats:** Well-resourced APT groups target strategic systems (satellites, ICS, banking, C2). They perform *sophisticated, prolonged intrusions* for espionage or disruption ². Such actors use custom toolchains and take great care to avoid detection. They may capture decoy artifacts but are expert at evading simple traps. This system’s polymorphism and stealth aim to counter advanced adversaries.
- **Cybercriminals / Opportunists:** Profit-driven criminals and ransomware gangs are typically *opportunistic* and less patient ³. They rely on stolen data and exploit tools at scale. Our prion artifacts still catch these attackers: any access attempts (even automated) trigger alerts. For example, fraudulent use of fake API keys or tokens would be logged and defended internally.
- **Insiders/Hacktivists:** Moderately skilled insiders or hacktivists pose a lower-level threat but might also trigger our traps. They help us by interacting with decoys, usually noisily, which is easier to detect.
- **Hybrid threats:** Emerging patterns (e.g. state actors outsourcing to criminals) mean lines blur ³. Our design must consider all: it should mislead both tech-savvy and casual attackers.

Threat Type	Characteristics	Defensive Focus
Nation-state APT	Highly skilled, well-funded, stealthy, long-term; often custom malware	Stealthy artifacts, polymorphic, deep telemetry to profile their tools.
Criminal opportunists	Profit-motivated, commodity tools (ransomware, infostealers); broad attack	Detect beacon triggers quickly; trap credentials to catch “spray” attacks.
Insiders/hacktivists	Varies skill; may have legitimate access or insider knowledge	Tailor decoys to internal use cases; escalate on anomalies.

By understanding these profiles, we tune the prion artifacts: e.g. **timing** (delaying alerts to long dwell operations), **fingerprinting** (detect VM analysis), and multi-stage triggers for deep threats.

Technical Design Overview

Our “prion defense” system comprises: **decoy artifacts** implanted in real systems, a **telemetry ingestion backend**, and **analytics/response** components. The artifacts are inert pieces of data or interfaces that mimic real assets (sessions, tokens, telemetry packets), yet contain hidden sensors. When an attacker steals or interacts with them outside the protected network, the artifact quietly “pings” home (via DNS/HTTPS/API) with metadata about its host environment. Internally, we replicate these artifacts (prion-like) and feed all signals into a SIEM, which triggers defensive measures upon detecting malicious patterns.

¹¹

- **Deception Benefits:** Early warning of targeting, lateral movement, and data exfiltration attempts ¹¹.

Each artifact yields a high-fidelity alert if touched. - **Polymorphism:** Artifacts appear different each instance/iteration (random IDs, timestamps, encryption tags) to avoid fingerprinting ⁵ ¹² .

Artifact Types and Formats

We may use multiple forms: **HTTP cookies/sessions, API keys, configuration files, fake telemetry streams**, etc. Examples:

- A fake satellite telemetry packet or cloud metadata object with embedded callback.
- A decoy API token that looks valid.
- A dummy Active Directory user/honey account embedded in logs, with unique cookie.

Each artifact carries an ID and “contact back” logic (e.g. an embedded URL or DNS request template). All artifacts are designed to look *legitimate* for the environment (names, formats, timing), so attackers treat them as real assets ⁵ ¹³ .

Format	Use Case	Polymorphism Strategy	Stealth Consideration
Session Cookie	Web/Cloud interfaces	Change cookie values, encryption, domain patterns periodically.	Use normal HTTP(S) headers and random intervals.
API Token/Key	Service APIs, IoT endpoints	Vary token string, scopes, creation times.	Log usage internally; no unusual rights.
Telemetry Packet	ICS/SCADA or satellite links	Randomize payload fields, mimic noise patterns.	Send using standard protocol channels; no unusual headers.
Config File/Doc	Documents or config stolen	Embed benign fields (e.g. harmless metadata); unique markers.	Use realistic file formats; remove “tell”.

Polymorphism Strategies

- **Variable Encoding/Metadata:** Each artifact includes random salts, timestamps, or keys to ensure no two look alike. For example, cookies may have dynamic token values or expiration fields that change each time they are accessed internally.
- **Dynamic Content:** Payload content (e.g. telemetry fields) changes over time or per instance, based on real-time network conditions or scheduled jobs.
- **Contextual Variation:** Different system architectures get slightly different versions of artifacts so that stolen data from one site can be distinguished from another.

Internal Replication (“Mitosis”)

When an artifact is triggered by a likely attack (e.g. unusual access pattern, external IP), the system **spawns clones** internally to cover more ground:

- The SIEM or orchestration can automatically create additional decoy entries (e.g. new honey accounts or telemetry endpoints) in adjacent subnets or systems.
- Clone artifacts inherit original patterns but get new polymorphic markers.
- This “mitosis” ensures that attackers who dig deeper keep hitting decoys without obvious pattern.

Environment Fingerprinting (Activation Conditions)

Artifacts remain silent until they detect a foreign environment. Possible triggers:

- **Network Check:** The artifact checks source IP or DNS resolution; if it falls outside known corporate IP ranges, it prepares telemetry.
- **Host Profile:** If running on a machine with unexpected OS or lacking corporate certificates, it alters behavior.
- **Tool Presence:** Detection of analysis tools or debuggers (e.g. presence of `Wireshark`, virtualization flags) can gate activation, per [2] recommendations (fingerprint attacker tools) ¹⁴.
- **Time Delay:** The artifact may wait (minutes/hours) or require multiple interactions before pinging back, reducing chance of discovery by quick scans ⁹ ¹⁵.

These measures ensure the artifact's "beacon" only fires in a hostile context, **never inside our network** (avoiding false triggers).

Stealth Ping-Back Protocols

When activated, the artifact must signal back without raising suspicion in the attacker's environment. Techniques include:

- **DNS Beacons:** Artifacts make DNS queries (e.g. a subdomain like `abc123.defense-us.gov`), which our DNS-controlled server logs. DNS traffic is common and can slip by firewalls.
- **HTTPS Callbacks:** A benign HTTPS request to a carefully chosen (and registered) domain. For example, the artifact's code might load an innocuous image or JSON from `telemetry.c2.example.com?id=XYZ`. Traffic looks like normal web queries.
- **Steganographic Channels:** Though more complex, minor timing variations or payload size can encode additional data (e.g. user-agent strings, packet timing).

All communication uses our infrastructure. Under [2] "Return channel" analysis, callbacks are standard practice ¹⁶. We keep payload minimal and protocol-native to blend in.

Telemetry Collection Schema

The backend logs only what the artifact voluntarily reports. Typical fields:

- **Artifact ID:** Unique ID of the decoy.
- **Timestamp:** When interaction occurred.
- **Source IP & Geo:** IP address where the callback originated (maps attacker location).
- **Host Info:** If possible, OS fingerprint (via user-agent or slight header differences), hostnames, network hops.
- **Session Data:** Any attacker-provided headers, cookies (attackers might send back unknown cookies), TLS handshake info.
- **Environment Markers:** If the artifact can detect VM presence or tool usage, those flags.

This data is ingested into a SIEM (or custom analytics) for correlation and alerting ¹³. We only collect **environmental metadata**; no user data or unauthorized info from attacker is sought.

Detection vs Avoidance Trade-offs

Our design balances visibility to our defense with invisibility to the attacker:

- **Stealth (Attacker Blindness):** Artifacts must closely mimic real assets. According to recent research, advanced attackers can fingerprint naive honeytokens ¹². Thus we must ensure high realism (detailed attributes, legitimate-looking files) and polymorphism ⁵ ¹².
- **Signal Strength (Detection by Us):** The more unique telemetry we collect, the richer the intelligence. Embedding more “fingerprint triggers” (e.g. fake fields) increases clues but risks detection. We aim for controlled minimalism: invisible “beacons” only to us.
- **Performance Impact:** Internal replication and ping routines should not overload our network. Light-weight tokens and low-frequency callbacks preserve resources.

Strategy	Benefits	Risks / Detection
Passive honeytokens	Purely defensive; legal safe; simple to deploy (just logs alerts) ⁵ .	Attackers may detect static tokens (research shows fingerprinting attacks ¹²).
Ping-back via DNS/HTTP	Strong telemetry channel; uses common ports (stealthy) ¹⁶ .	Could be blocked by strict egress filtering; possible network logs on attacker side.
Polymorphic replication	High cover; adversary confusion; increases hunting data.	Complexity to manage clones; potential for redundant alerts.
Environment gating	Prevents false triggers; lawful by design ⁹ .	If fingerprinting imperfect, may miss actual attacks (false negatives).

Operational Playbook

Deployment

1. **Environment Mapping:** Identify critical assets (satellite feeds, ICS nodes, HSM APIs, domain controllers) where decoys will be placed.
2. **Artifact Seeding:** Create and distribute diverse artifacts (see table) across systems, ensuring they blend with real assets. For example, plant fake telemetry API endpoints in satellite control software, or dummy database credentials in SCADA logs.
3. **Connectivity Setup:** Configure the decoys so that if accessed, they attempt to “call home” to our secure collection point (via embedded scripts or links). Use subdomains and domains under our control.
4. **Monitoring Integration:** Add alerts in SIEM/UEBA rules to catch any use of decoy artifacts. E.g. watch for connections to the registered beacon domains or login attempts to dummy accounts ¹³.

Monitoring & Escalation

- **Alert Levels:** Define rules (e.g. any interaction with a decoy = alert). Tiered response: immediate high-severity if multiple decoys triggered or if suspected nation-state signatures (custom tool fingerprints) are detected.
- **Correlation:** Correlate with other logs (IDS, EDR). If decoy use aligns with suspicious lateral movement, escalate.

- **Isolation:** Upon confirmed threat, segment or isolate affected networks. For ICS, switch to safe mode if decoy is triggered by remote control attempts.
- **Intelligence Handoff:** Package collected metadata and share with threat intel teams for attribution, as it may reveal attacker infrastructure or TTPs.

Escalation Rules Example

- *One decoy trigger:* Alert SOC to investigate.
- *Multiple decoys or repeated accesses:* Automatically isolate that subnet or VLAN.
- *High-confidence pattern (e.g. known APT tool sig matched):* Notify CISO, engage law enforcement/ partners.

Mermaid sequence diagram for a typical interaction:

```
sequenceDiagram
    participant Attacker
    participant Artifact
    participant SIEM
    participant Analyst
    Attacker->>Artifact: Steals and uses it
    Artifact-->>SIEM: Sends telemetry (IP, host, context)
    SIEM->>Analyst: Generates alert ("Decoy used in foreign net")
    Analyst->>SIEM: Correlate with other logs
    Analyst->>Defender: Isolate segment / revoke cred
```

Figure: Flow of attacker interacting with a prion artifact, beaconing telemetry, and defender response.

Deployment Checklist

- □ Ensure all artifact payloads are signed or controlled so they cannot be replaced by adversary.
- □ Test beacon channels (DNS, HTTPS) from outside to confirm logs appear.
- □ Document decoy attributes so alerts are clear (do not confuse them with real assets).
- □ Conduct internal red-team drills to tune stealth (simulate attacker fingerprinting/hardening).

Failure Modes & Mitigations

Failure Mode	Impact	Mitigation
Artifact Detection by Attacker	They avoid or remove decoys	Continually refresh polymorphism; embed in normal assets ¹² .
Beacons Blocked by Attacker's Firewall	No telemetry collected	Use multiple channels (DNS fallback, ICMP covert channels).
Internal Triggering (False Positives)	Wasted alerts	Strict environment checks (IP whitelist) and honeypots time-locked ⁹ .

Failure Mode	Impact	Mitigation
Cascading Failure (loop)	Self-DDoS of SIEM	Limit replication rate; have kill-switch to disable extra cloning.
Legal/Policy Breach	Non-compliance risk	Strict logging of all actions; regular audit; kill off any artifact showing unexpected behavior.

Key mitigations include rigorous fingerprinting and fail-safes: e.g., no decoy “arm” unless in foreign net ⁹, and ability to deactivate beacons if misrouted. Automated monitoring of the decoy system itself (meta-monitoring) prevents self-inflicted outages.

Ethics and Compliance Checklist

- **Consent & Purpose:** System is strictly for defensive cyber intel. Maintain a clear log that no legitimate user data is captured.
 - **Minimization:** Collect only environment and attack pattern data, not content. Discard any unrelated personal data if encountered.
 - **Proportionality:** Alerts and any automated response actions are proportional (e.g. isolate segments only on confirmed intrusion).
 - **Transparency:** Document policies internally. Ensure operations personnel are trained on legal limits (don’t misconstrue intelligence as permission for hack-back).
 - **Oversight:** Periodic legal review (especially of any “active” component). Possibly involve a compliance officer.
- These align with *purpose limitation*, *proportionality* and *minimization* principles ⁷. All tools should include audit logs to review that actions stayed within bounds.

Implementation Roadmap

```

timeline
    title Development Timeline (2026)
    2026-Q2 : Requirements & Design Specifications
    2026-Q3 : Prototype Artifact Creation (Python/Go)
    2026-Q4 : Internal Testbed Deployment (Emulated ICS/cloud)
    2027-Q1 : Red Team Trials & Tuning (Stealth polish)
    2027-Q2 : Pilot Deployment in Production Environment
    2027-Q3 : Scale-up & Automation (Dynamic cloning logic)
    2027-Q4 : Full Operational Rollout & Metrics Monitoring

```

- **Languages:** Start with **Python** for rapid POC (especially for generating HTTP/DNS beacons), consider **Go** or **Rust** for lightweight long-running telemetry agents. Use standard frameworks (e.g. Flask, FastAPI, or gRPC) to simulate services.
- **Testbed Architecture:** Set up a virtual lab replicating target domains (e.g. a simulated satellite control network, ICS system, and enterprise domain). Use adversary emulation tools to attack decoys (try known APT toolkits).

- **Metrics:** Key metrics include *time to detection* (from theft to alert), *false positive rate*, *reliability of beaconing* (percentage of triggers successfully received), and *adversary engagement depth* (how many decoys engaged). Track also *performance overhead* and *usability* (admin alert fatigue).

Mermaid Architecture Diagrams

```
graph LR
    subgraph Defender_Network [Defender Network]
        Decoy1[Decoy Artifact 1] --monitored by--> SIEM
        Decoy2[Decoy Artifact 2] --monitored by--> SIEM
        SIEM --alerts to--> IR_Team["IR Team"]
        SIEM --orders clones to--> Cloner["Cloner Service"]
        Cloner --creates--> Decoy3[Decoy Artifact 3]
    end
    subgraph Attacker_Environment [Attacker Environment]
        Attacker["Attacker Host"]
        Attacker --uses--> Decoy1
        Decoy1 --pings--> SIEM
    end
```

Figure: System architecture showing prion artifacts (Decoy1/2/3) in the defender network, attacker interaction, SIEM processing, and internal replication.

```
graph TD
    Adversary(Attacker) -->|Obtains artifact| Artifact(Decoy Artifact)
    Artifact -->|Detect foreign env| Trigger{Fingerprint}
    Trigger -->|Yes| Beacon[Ping Back to US Server]
    Trigger -->|No| Silent[No action]
    Beacon -->|Metadata| SIEM[Defender SIEM/Analytics]
    SIEM -->|Correlates & Alerts| DefenderOps
    SIEM -->|Replicate command| Cloner
    Cloner --> Artifact
```

Figure: Lifecycle of a prion artifact: attacker triggers beacon, fingerprinting logic checks environment, telemeters to SIEM, which alerts defenders and possibly spawns new decoys internally.

Design Option Comparison

Option	Pros	Cons	Use Case
Passive Honeytoken	Simple, safe (no outward code) ⁵ .	Limited info (only “touched” or not).	Low-risk alerting; initial defense.
Active Beacon (DNS/HTTP)	Rich telemetry (IP, host) ¹⁶ .	Requires code execution on host.	Deep dive intel on attacker infra.

Option	Pros	Cons	Use Case
Polymorphic Token	Harder to fingerprint ¹² .	More complex management.	High-value target zones.
Cloned Artifacts	Increases coverage.	Must manage inventory; possible loops.	Extended intrusion scenarios.

The mix of these approaches yields maximal coverage while preserving stealth.

Conclusion

This CENTEL-grade prion-defense blueprint enables U.S. defenders to **exploit stolen decoys as intelligence multipliers** without breaking legal or ethical boundaries ¹ ⁴. The system is **passive** and **environment-specific**, only responding to voluntary attacker actions. By embedding stealthy, polymorphic beacons across our critical networks, we ensure that adversaries (nation-state or criminal) unwittingly map their own presence while believing they've exfiltrated secrets. The thoughtful design, guided by CFAA compliance and defense-in-depth, makes any "attack" on our decoys a self-revealing trap ¹ ⁵. Implementing this approach could dramatically shift the strategic balance, forcing foes to tread lightly or risk exposure.

Sources: Legal and technical principles drawn from government and scholarly guidance ¹ ⁸ ⁵, threat intelligence analyses ² ³, and current deception engineering best practices ¹¹ ¹².

¹ ⁶ ⁷ ⁸ ⁹ ¹⁰ ¹⁴ ¹⁵ ¹⁶ Passive Hack-Back Strategies for Cyber Attribution: Covert Vectors in Denied Environments

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⁴ (PDF) The Legal Limits of Cyber Self-Defense: Where Should Companies Draw the Line?

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/397033104_The_Legal_Limits_of_Cyber_Self-Defense_Where_Should_Companies_Draw_the_Line

⁵ ¹² unpaywall.org

https://unpaywall.org/10.1007%2F978-3-031-22295-5_6

¹¹ ¹³ Detection via Deception — Using your SIEM as a Free Deception Platform | by Rcegan | Mar, 2026 | Detect FYI

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